

DAT246 – ABC & Case Study Exam Question Map (2021 – 2026)

(Expanded 2-page reference • English + ■■■■■)

1 ■■ ABC Framework (Stol et al., 2018)

Axes: Actors (■■■), Behavior (■■), Context (■■). Research positioned by **obtrusiveness** (■■■■) and **generalizability** (■■■■).

Eight strategies: Field Study, Field Experiment, Experimental Simulation, Lab Experiment, Judgment Study, Sample Study, Formal Theory, Computer Simulation.

Trade-off triangle: Cannot maximize **realism** (■■■■), **precision** (■■■■), and **generalizability** (■■■■) simultaneously.

Key phrase: “Seek generalizability over responses, not over the population of actors.” → Focus on behavioral patterns (■■■■) not samples of people.

Year(s)	Typical Question	Exam Focus / Expected Answer Points
2021–2023	Which of the eight strategies fits this paper? Justify with context.	Identify strategy (■■■■ vs ■■■■) → justify with context (■■■■).
2022–2024	Explain ‘generalizability over responses’.	Analytical generalization (■■■■) focus on behavioral patterns (■■■■).
2023–2025	Tension between experiments and observation.	Relate to validity types: experiments ↑ internal validity (■■■■).
2025+	How to select a strategy using the ABC High Goal, Obtrusiveness, and desired generalizability.	High goal, Obtrusiveness, and desired generalizability (■■■■).

Exam Tips for ABC Questions:

- Always mention axes and trade-offs.
- Relate strategy choice to validity threats (Construct / Internal / External / Reliability).

2 ■■ Case Study Research (Yin 2003; Runeson & Höst 2009; Flyvbjerg 2006)

Definition: Empirical study of a contemporary phenomenon within its real-life context (■■■■). Uses multiple evidence sources (■■■■).

Purpose: Explore (■■), Describe (■■), Explain (■■), Improve (■■).

Types: Theory Building (Eisenhardt 1989 ■■■), Theory Testing (Yin 2003 ■■■), Problem Solving (Van de Ven 2007 ■■■).

Design Steps (5): Design → Prepare → Collect → Analyze → Report.

Validity (■■): Construct ■■, Internal ■■, External ■■, Reliability ■■ → use triangulation (■■■■) and protocol (■■■■).

Misunderstandings (Flyvbjerg 2006): Cannot generalize from 1 case ■; Case study biased ■; Hard to summarize ■ → rich context adds value.

Year(s)	Typical Question	Expected Answer Highlights
2021–2023	Define case study research and main characteristics.	Contextual study; multiple sources; analytical (■■■■).
2022–2024	Three types of case study and their goals.	Theory Building → explore; Testing → validate; Problem Solving → solve (■■■■).
2023–2024	Main steps in conducting a case study.	Design – Prepare – Collect – Analyze – Report (5 steps) (■■■■).
2024–2025	Explain the four validity types and how to ensure them.	Triangulation; Internal → control context (■■■■).
2025+	Identify a common misunderstanding about case studies.	Generalize from one case → False (■■■■).

3 ■■ Integrative / Applied Exam Questions (ABC + Case Study Combined)

Typical prompt (2022 → 2025):

“Below follows an abstract. Which ABC research strategy does it fit? Justify and discuss main validity threats.”

Answer pattern (8–10 pts):

- 1 ■■ Identify strategy (e.g. Field Study / Lab Experiment).
- 2 ■■ Justify using ABC axes (realism, obtrusiveness, context).
- 3 ■■ List validity threats (Construct, Internal, External, Reliability).
- 4 ■■ Explain trade-offs (high context realism ■ low control etc.).

Key link: ABC focus on **strategy choice** (■■■■■■); Case Study focus on **execution and validity** (■■■■■■) – together they cover design and evaluation in empirical SE.

Predicted 2026+ Questions (■■■■■):

Question Focus	Expected Reasoning
Define ABC framework + draw trade-off triangle axes, 8 strategies, realism vs precision vs generalizability.	High goal, Obtrusiveness, and desired generalizability (■■■■).
Interpret ‘generalizability over responses’.	Analytical generalization → patterns not actors (■■■■).

Outline 5 steps of case study and relate to validity	Show how each step mitigates threats (e.g. protocol ↑ reliability)
Discuss how ABC and case study approaches select the work; Case Study = method example	

Exam Tip: When in doubt, link **ABC axes** → **strategy choice** and **validity types** → **case study execution**. This structure alone secures most points.